

his ideas to be appreciated. He was perhaps the last great thinking mathematician (or possibly the reverse, a mathematical thinker). Every time I see a T-shirt bearing the picture of the modern icon Albert Einstein, I cannot help thinking of Poincaré—Einstein is worthy of our reverence, but he has displaced many others. There is so little room in our consciousness; it is winner-take-all up there.

Third Republic—Style Decorum

Again, Poincaré is in a class by himself. I recall my father recommending Poincaré's essays, not just for their scientific content, but for the quality of his French prose. The grand master wrote these wonders as serialized articles and composed them like extemporaneous speeches. As in every masterpiece, you see a mixture of repetitions, digressions, everything a “me too” editor with a prepackaged mind would condemn—but these make his text even more readable owing to an iron consistency of thought.

Poincaré became a prolific essayist in his thirties. He seemed in a hurry and died prematurely, at fifty-eight; he was in such a rush that he did not bother correcting typos and grammatical errors in his text, even after spotting them, since he found doing so a gross misuse of his time. They no longer make geniuses like that—or they no longer let them write in their own way.

Poincaré's reputation as a thinker waned rapidly after his death. His idea that concerns us took almost a century to resurface, but in another form. It was indeed a great mistake that I did not carefully read his essays as a child, for in his magisterial *La science et l'hypothèse*, I discovered later, he angrily disparages the use of the bell curve.

I will repeat that Poincaré was the true kind of philosopher of science: his philosophizing came from his witnessing the limits of the subject itself, which is what true philosophy is all about. I love to tick off French literary intellectuals by naming Poincaré as my favorite French philosopher. “*Him a philosophe? What do you mean, monsieur?*” It is always frustrating to explain to people that the thinkers they put on the pedestals, such as Henri Bergson or Jean-Paul Sartre, are largely the result of fashion production and can't come close to Poincaré in terms of sheer influence that will continue for centuries to come. In fact, there is a scandal of prediction going on here, since it is the French Ministry of National Education that decides who is a philosopher and which philosophers need to be studied.

I am looking at Poincaré's picture. He was a bearded, portly and imposing, well-educated patrician gentleman of the French Third Republic, a man who lived and breathed general science, looked deep into his subject, and had an